

“

Domestic help, drivers and working hands come from slums. These slum-dwellers are complementary to urban growth, not a burden.

RAJENDRA JOSHI, Founder, Saath

”

Joshi then launched an education programme involving the local youth and women, won their confidence and co-opted them into Saath. Responsibilities were entrusted as part of his plan to upgrade Gupta Nagar with help from the Ahmedabad Municipal Corporation.

In the mid-90s, Gupta Nagar had neither electricity, toilets nor 24-hour potable water. Residents squatted in an open plot amongst bushes, woke up at 5 a.m. and queued up to get potable water. Cut to 2008—every house has water, power and a toilet. Says resident Jyotsnaben Ahir, now a producer in Saath's video communication division, Samvaad, “When I came here 25

years ago, it was a breeding ground for waterborne diseases. The change is dramatic.

Yet Joshi is opposed to the Jawahar Nehru National Urban Renewal Mission which aims to wipe out shanty-towns by providing housing in new, low-cost buildings, says the Government can't build enough homes for all the slum-dwellers. Ahmedabad alone, only 25,000 homes have been allocated against a demand of over three lakh. Joshi's biggest challenge is making private players look at the urban poor as a market and not as objects of charity. He also wants to make government agencies accept payment of services from them. “Society can't forget that domestic helpers, drivers and working hands come from slums and they cannot function without them. They are complementary to a city's growth, not a burden,” he says. His wife, five years, Bela, manages Saath's Home Managers project, training slum women to become high-end help.

For Joshi, if Ahmedabad's choicest clusters can be converted into model estates that its citizens can be proud of, the same is possible all over the country. A rainbow to ride on, to turn a squatter into a stayer.

Transcend the mundane, reach the sublime,

Behold tranquility and peace in a warp of time.

Meditate on the blessings of the Lord's grace,

Which endows this state with a heavenly face.



Incredible India

www.himachaltourism.nic.in

Himachal

HIMACHAL PRADESH - There is always one more reason to go!



Bajreshwari Devi Temple,



Chamunda Ji



Jwalaji Temple



Shiv Temple Baijnath

Plan your holidays with more than 50 HPTDC hotels at the click of a mouse: www.hptdc.gov.in

• Himachal Tourism, Block No.: 28, S.D.A Complex, Kasumpti. Shimla-171009. Ph.: 0177-2625511, 2623959, 2625924, Fax: 0177-2625864. E-mail: tourismmin-hp@nic.in, www.himachaltourism.nic.in For online bookings visit: www.hptdc.gov.in, www.himachalhotels.in > **Tourist Information Centres** • Delhi: 011-23324764, 23325320 • Mumbai: 022-22181123, 22180080 • Kolkata: 033-22126361 • Chennai: 044-25385689 • Bangalore: 080-22876591 • Ahmedabad: 079-27544800 • Chandigarh: 0172-2707267, 2708569 • Kalka: 01733-221079 • Pathankot: 0186-2220316 • Dalhousie: 01899-242225 • Dharamshala: 01892-221205, 221232 • Manali: 01902-252175, 252325 • Shimla: 0177-2832498, 2652561, 2654589.

**Toll Free
1800 1**